The first row has screen-shots of GNOME Shell, and the second row of Unity, on a netbook. The columns have: a) Start-up screen, b) Select/launch app, c) Nautilus.

supports them. The applications may also be using the 'Status Tray Protocol' specifications (*http://standards.freedesktop.org/systemtray-spec/*) implemented by GNOME 2 and KDE. These specifications use X11 protocols and do not use DBUS, and are not supposed to be used in GNOME 3—though they seem to be available in the message tray as legacy *Xembed* notification icons. Unity wants applications to use *appindicator*, which implements the DBUS status notifier specification (http://www.notmart.org/misc/statusnotifieritem/index.html), also used by KDE 4. Unity includes the system tray only for a few specific applications via a 'white-list'. You can use the command '*gsettings*' to enable the notification area for all applications.

The last group is system applets like Network Manager or Volume Control. These are expected to be managed by the desktop manager. In both GNOME Shell and Unity, they continue to appear in the panel; GNOME Shell uses Javascript to make this happen. You may wish to explore */usr/share/gnome-shell/js/ui/panel.js* to know more about the fixed status icons.

For GNOME Shell to treat system applets differently from applets that use the message tray, bothers me. You should not have to think whether it is a system icon or an application icon, and then look in the appropriate area. Once the network is working, why do you need the icon to be visible? In fact, if some icons do not need to be always visible, I would have voted for the system icons to be out of sight.

GNOME Shell Extensions, Unity Indicators

One of the ways in which GNOME desktop functionality got extended was with GNOME Panel applets. However, GNOME Panel is not used by either GNOME Shell or Unity—and neither has support, or plans for supporting panel applets. However, GNOME Panel is used by both GNOME Shell and Unity in the fall-back mode. Also, GNOME Panel for GNOME 3 is being modified substantially. So, are applets going to be obsolete? It makes no sense to develop or maintain even small applications, if they are to be used only in the fall-back mode.

A major change in GNOME Shell is the introduction of extensions written in Javascript, which are much better integrated with the shell than GNOME applets. A fair number of extensions have been developed: e.g., to add the *Places* menu and a dock which remains visible. At least at present, it does not seem as if the GNOME Shell extensions will run on Unity—but then, they will not run in the fall-back mode of GNOME Shell either. Furthermore, the WebOS example indicates that the use of Javascript to write extensions does not necessarily guarantee success.

It took some time for KDE4 to settle. The same is undoubtedly going to be the case for Unity and GNOME Shell. You can look forward to Unity on GNOME 3 and, most likely, someone will bring Unity indicators to GNOME Shell using Javascript extensions. END

By: Anil Seth

The author currently works as a consultant, prior to which he was a professor at Padre Conceicao College of Engineering (PCCE) in Goa. He has managed IT and imaging solutions for Phil Corporation Limited (Goa), supported domestic customers for Tata Burroughs/TIL, and was a researcher with IIT-K and the Indian Institute of Geomagnetism (Mumbai). You can find him online at *http://sethanil.com* and reach him via email at *anil@sethanil.com*.